

Stings and venom

When a rattlesnake goes hunting, it has no need to overpower its prey. Instead, it stabs its victim with its fangs and then waits while its deadly venom sets to work. Poisoning is an efficient and safe method of killing because it prevents prey from fighting back. Snakes are among the largest animals with a poisonous bite, but animals with a toxic sting outnumber them by far. The most deadly animal poisons are not produced for hunting—instead, they provide poison dart frogs with the ultimate means of self-defense.

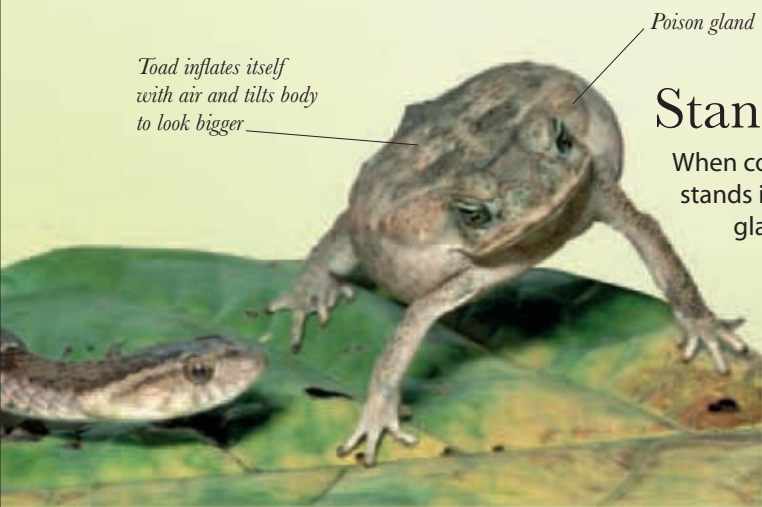


Toad inflates itself with air and tilts body to look bigger

Poison gland

Standoff

When confronted by a snake, a cane toad puffs up its body and stands its ground, instead of trying to escape. It has bulging glands just behind its eyes that ooze poisons onto its skin. The poisons protect the toad from most predators, although some snakes are immune to its effects. Originally from the American tropics, the cane toad's growing population has become a major problem in Australia, where it has no natural enemies.



Wasp's sting withdraws into abdomen when not in use

